

***Evaluating the efficiency and
transparency of national
anti-corruption agencies***

Commission on Crime Prevention & Criminal Justice (CCPCJ)

I. Introduction

Worldwide, almost every nation faces issues tied to corruption. Though often hidden, it weakens government operations alongside trust in leadership and economic progress. Instead of fading, these patterns persist without oversight, while bodies focused on integrity help maintain openness in decision-making processes. Their presence shifts how power is monitored across administrative frameworks.

Though they were initially created to spot, stop, or examine corruption, anti-corruption agencies (ACAs) differ widely in how they function. Divergence tends to stem not just from legal powers, but also from how independent each body is within government frameworks. United Nations guidelines may shape some institutions more than others, depending on local adoption patterns. Where state oversight dominates, autonomy usually shrinks. Success emerges not uniformly but follows clearer paths when interference remains limited. Ultimately, results reflect not only mandates but also hidden pressures shaping daily operations.

Honesty among participants could allow full clarity, yet real-world settings rarely meet that standard. Questions emerge about timing - when ought global bodies lead anti-graft actions instead of local ones? Oversight tightening for country-level offices might follow another path. Domestic frameworks possibly hold stronger tools, given proper support later on.

II. Definition of Key Terms

Corruption

Corruption is the dishonest, fraudulent, or criminal use of entrusted authority or power for personal gain or other unlawful or unethical benefits. Corruption occurs in politics, business, education, media, and other social and economic fields. A lack of transparency, accountability, and effective regulation are common causes of corruption. Corruption undermines institutional reputation and effectiveness, destabilizes governance, hinders economic development, distorts individual rights and freedoms, and weakens democracy and justice.

Anti-Corruption Agency

Anti-Corruption Agencies are specialized public institutions mandated by the state to prevent , detect, investigate and combat corruption, through law enforcement, oversight and preventive measures. These institutions typically operate with a degree of operational independence,

collaborating with international organizations, as well as domestic law enforcement, in order to enforce anti-corruption laws, promote integrity in public administration, and strengthen accountability mechanisms.

Transparency

Transparency is the principle and practice by which institutions make information about their decisions, processes, and activities openly available, accessible, and understandable to the public, thereby enabling accountability, oversight, and informed participation in governance. Transparency is therefore imperative in countering potential misuse of power, such as corruption.

Bribery

Bribery is the act of offering, giving, receiving, or soliciting any undue advantage—financial or otherwise—with the intent of influencing the actions or decisions of a public official or other person in a position of authority, in violation of legal or ethical duties. Bribery is often difficult to prove, yet very prevalent in politics or any other high-interest areas of activity.



III. Background Information

Development of Global Anti-Corruption Agencies

From the 1990s onward, curbing corruption became prominent within global discussions. At the time, the United Nations launched several initiatives aimed at reducing corrupt practices, which eventually led to the creation of the United Nations Convention against Corruption in 2003. The agreement outlines broad strategies involving prevention and judicial enforcement, along with cross-border collaboration. Compliance requires nations to adjust national laws so they reflect agreed standards. Achieving common goals depends upon consistent implementation across countries. Meanwhile, regional efforts emerged alongside one another, among them, the African Union's pact on corruption and the Organization of American States' treaty targeting corrupt practices. At the same time, global bodies like the OECD and the World Bank release guidance meant to strengthen openness, responsibility, and sound institutions. In similar fashion, civil society groups contribute significantly by observing adherence and informing communities. Lately, attention has shifted further than just applying rules. Greater weight goes toward assessing government bodies, alongside building skills among inquiry officers and court staff. Staying capable demands constant adjustment by global and local organizations alike as political changes appear and new tools emerge. Effectiveness against misconduct grows when systems evolve without pause.

Types of National Anti-Corruption Agencies

A broad variety of national anti-corruption agencies operate globally, each shaped by distinct institutional frameworks and methods. Where one system may link investigators tightly with police and courts, another operates apart through dedicated legal units. Instead of splitting duties, some nations assign both probing and charging powers to singular prosecutor offices focused solely on graft. Meanwhile, a few states have formed unified institutions, which handle investigations while running outreach programs and safeguarding those who report misconduct. Depending on the country, how much power an agency holds shapes its ability to perform. Where one stands globally often depends upon adherence to frameworks promoted by entities like the OECD or UNODC. Yet alignment does not mean replications; blueprints shift based on local governance traditions. Functionality emerges less from design than from fit within existing systems. What works in one setting may fail elsewhere to different norms

Measuring Efficiency and Transparency

One way to measure how well anti-corruption agencies operate involves numerical data. Although numbers provide structure, they do not always reflect real impact. For instance, time spent on

probes might suggest delays or thoroughness depending on context. Recovered funds appear useful at first glance, yet their size alone cannot confirm effectiveness. Resource distribution compared to results often reveals mismatches hidden beneath surface figures.

Despite numerical data, performance appraisal relies also on reviews from within and assessments conducted externally. Reporting bodies like the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime aid transparency by issuing studies alongside supporting cross-national scrutiny processes. Such metrics tend to reflect real-world operations rather than abstract ideals. One illustration involves the Philippines Ombudsman disclosing yearly totals of resolved integrity violations. Meanwhile, Singapore's agency focused on misconduct details about probes carried out along with recovered property linked to wrongdoings.

Still, skill development initiatives, alongside oversight systems, form core elements when assessing performance, as they help limit incidents tied to corrupt practices. From such a broad strategy emerges clarity on effective organizations, while also exposing zones needing refinement.



IV. Current Situation and Global Challenges

Structural Challenges in Anti-Corruption Systems

It is often difficult for anti-corruption agencies to function effectively due to weaknesses in national laws and structures. Where such bodies exist, their authority can be limited by interference from government elites. As a result, scrutiny of senior officials or corporate leaders tends to encounter resistance. Independence becomes fragile whenever those under review hold considerable sway.

Above all else, responsibility splits across many institutions. Where legal authority exists in pieces, separate agencies handle different parts of anti-corruption work; some prevent, others probe, a few prosecute, while more watch over the process. Without clear links between them, efforts slow down, and sometimes they stall completely. At times, it is red tape that deepens delays. Lengthy court routines stretch timelines so far that matters simply linger without closure.

Complications in today's corrupt practices deepen existing problems. Often, such instances include international money flows, third parties, or online tools, each raising the burden on domestic oversight frameworks. Because of this shift, enforcement actions lose strength while outcomes grow less certain.

Global Trends in Anti-Corruption Policies and Governance

In recent times, changes across nations have helped grow efforts to reduce corruption by making systems more open and improving oversight of government workers. Where certain rules now exist, leaders must reveal details about money matters, property holdings, or possible biases; this shift tends to limit chances for hiding improper conduct.

Using new digital tools like open data sites and web-based reporting, governments shape settings where dishonest actions find less room, at the same time allowing clearer views into how public duties unfold. Because misconduct often hides in global money flows and linked structures, stronger reactions now rest heavily on steady coordination between nations and worldwide bodies, especially when sharing insights or working probes together.

Meanwhile, focus has moved more toward stopping issues before they start. Professional development programs appear alongside compliance frameworks, while public outreach initiatives gain importance within these efforts. By targeting root causes, the strategy aims to lower chances that misconduct will happen. Preventive methods now shape much of how institutions respond

Differences in Institutional Capacity and Implementation

A nation's ability to carry out strong anti-corruption efforts rests upon several conditions. Financial means, alongside skilled personnel, is one essential component. Authority formally assigned to

relevant agencies enables their operation. Independence from external pressures shapes how freely such bodies act. Judicial systems that work properly contribute through checks and supervision. Because of these elements, putting anti-corruption measures into practice often unfolds in distinct ways across regions. Despite resembling one another on paper, national approaches may diverge sharply once applied, shaped by underlying conditions that alter their impact. Still, how a nation organizes its government deeply influences whether efforts against corruption succeed. Depending on a design, institutions may allow reforms to take hold. Alternatively, they might block progress before it begins. Power distribution shapes outcomes quietly yet firmly.



V. Major Countries and Organizations involved

Singapore - Corrupt Practices Investigation Bureau (CPIB)

Singapore's Corrupt Practices Investigation Bureau (CPIB) is often recognised as a benchmark for anti-corruption work. Since 1952, CPIB has been running independently under the Prime Minister's Office, without external influence or political interference. They investigate and prevent corruption both in government and private business, and their results speak for themselves. Singapore regularly lands at the very top of global rankings for clean governance. In Transparency International's 2024 Corruption Perceptions Index, Singapore made it into the top five least corrupt countries worldwide. That's not just a bragging point; it actually reflects how much people trust the system and CPIB's ability to get things done. Year after year, CPIB publishes statistics that show a high clearance and conviction rate, which underscores their effectiveness. They don't just stop at enforcement, either. CPIB tracks public opinion through regular surveys, and most respondents give them high marks for tackling corruption. On the international front, CPIB doesn't operate in isolation. They partner with groups like the United Nations Convention against Corruption, the OECD Anti-Corruption Initiative for Asia and the Pacific, and the G20 Anti-Corruption Working Group. That kind of collaboration ensures Singapore stays sharp, learning from global best practices and sharing their own methods.

Philippines - Office of the Ombudsman

In the Philippines, the Office of the Ombudsman is regarded as the most important government body responsible for combating corruption in the public sector. Since the adoption of the 1987 Constitution and the Ombudsman Act of 1989, the Office has exercised wide-ranging powers to investigate corrupt officials in public office, bring cases before the Anti-Corruption Court (Sandiganbayan) and recommend disciplinary action against corrupt officials. The Office also assists in the tracing and repatriation of illegally acquired funds. Over the decades, the Ombudsman has investigated thousands of cases; however, its track record is mixed. Many Filipinos question the office's effectiveness in combating serious corruption in the public service, particularly in connection with infrastructure projects or government contracts. There is a general public debate about the office's accountability and effectiveness in preventing and punishing large-scale abuses of power by officials.

Romania - National Anticorruption Directorate (DNA)

Romania's National Anti-Corruption Directorate (DNA) has developed into an exceptionally powerful institution in the fight against corruption. Particularly in cases involving mid-level and high-level officials, the DNA has made it clear that it does not hesitate to take action against politicians, judges and ministers. Under strong and effective leadership, the DNA has consistently

prosecuted a large and significant number of high-ranking defendants. Conviction rates often exceed 90%, which speaks volumes about the state of crime in Romania. This is also reflected in increased public confidence in the rule of law, which is attributable to the work of the DNA and has, over time, led to a weakening of the power of corruption in Romania. However, this process continues to proceed slowly, as evidenced by the results of the Global Corruption Index. Nevertheless, there is no doubt as to the direction in which the trend is moving.

South Africa - Multiple Institutions and Civil Society Actors

The fight against corruption in South Africa is not just the government's responsibility - it is a joint effort involving many people. Among the country's best police forces and investigators is the Directorate for the Prosecution of Serious Crimes (DPCI), which works closely with the National Prosecuting Authority, as well as several specialist units within the police force, to conduct investigations and gather evidence in order to prosecute those who have committed acts of corruption. Organizations such as Corruption Watch uncover cases of corruption, draw attention to the illegal activities of various members of society, and advocate for transparency and accountability. Through their collaboration, both government agencies and independent monitoring organizations are building a nation of integrity and good governance, where these principles are not merely empty phrases but genuine goals towards which both sides are working together.

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) works to encourage international standards for combating corruption by helping countries to fulfill their treaty obligations under the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC). This includes the provision of technical assistance and the sharing of best practices for overseeing and evaluating anti-corruption bodies in the various countries. The UNODC also provides support through the implementation of international cooperation in the areas of law enforcement, the provision of mutual legal assistance and capacity-building in the countries.

Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD)

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) is committed to the international fight against corruption through instruments such as the OECD Anti-Bribery Convention, integrity frameworks, and the promotion of consistent policies among its members through peer reviews of their measures, as well as through measurable enforcement and transparency. All these processes help to bridge the gaps in the implementation of anti-corruption initiatives by member countries, thereby strengthening the accountability of various forms of government.

Transparency International

Transparency International is regarded as an important force when it comes to fighting corruption. The organisation publishes the Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI), observes trends of corruption and rates the use of national anti-corruption measures while improving them in the private and the public sectors. But Transparency International does not act alone. In close alliances with governments, companies and others, they inform about corruption risks and support projects combating them.



VI. Timeline of Important Events

Year/Event	Description of event
1977 - Foreign Corrupt Practices Act (FCPA)	The United States enacts one of the first major laws criminalizing the bribery of foreign officials in international business transactions.
1996 - Inter-American Convention against Corruption	The Organization of American States adopts the first international treaty specifically addressing corruption.
1999 - Entry into force of the OECD Convention on Combating Bribery	The OECD Convention requires signatory states to criminalize bribery of foreign public officials in international business transactions between participating states.
2003 - Adoption of the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC) □ Entry into Force in 2005	The United Nations General Assembly adopts the first global legally binding instrument to combat corruption.
2015 - Adoption of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 16)	The United Nations includes the fight against corruption and transparent institutions as part of Sustainable Development Goal 16.
2021 - United Nations General Assembly Special Session on Corruption (UNGASS)	Member states adopt a political declaration reaffirming their commitment to strengthening global efforts to combat corruption.

VII. Previous International Efforts

Not so long ago, progress on fighting corruption began gaining ground across nations. Governments now tend to support stricter rules along with broader ties between countries. Back in 1996, a turning point came when the Organization of American States embraced the Inter-American Convention against Corruption. That pact became the initial regional effort demanding members make certain dishonest acts illegal, share investigative resources and set up channels for cross-border legal help.

Later on, during 1999, nations belonging to the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development formally agreed upon the OECD Anti-Bribery Convention. What shifted matters significantly came three years after that, specifically in 2003, with the UN General Assembly endorsing the United Nations Convention against Corruption. Rather than focusing narrowly, this agreement brought together multiple dimensions: deterrence strategies, legal penalties and reclaiming illicit assets, along with support through expertise. Active as of 2005, its structure gained more weight beginning in 2006 due to a monitoring system being out in place. Through structured evaluations conducted by fellow countries, compliance checks became routine, opening space for mutual learning across borders. Over time, such arrangements contributed meaningfully toward clearer governance norms accepted globally.

Still, laws by themselves fall short. Alongside them, global bodies add value through hands-on resources and field-level help. Take the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime: it delivers guidance and learning sessions and legislative examples alongside research outputs aimed at weakening corruption while building up system-wide abilities. Tools for tracking and reviewing anti-graft efforts have emerged from its work too. Beginning around the same time, assessments of corruption were embedded by the World Bank into its global governance data set. From that point onward, measurements related to legal frameworks and restraint of corrupt practices have been tracked in over two hundred nations. Reference points arising from these metrics inform policy adjustments pursued by state institutions and international aid organizations alike.

In 2015, attention to corruption intensified globally due to the introduction of the Sustainable Development Goals - Goal 16 specifically calling for institutions that are open and answerable while functioning reliably. Rather than being seen solely as breaking laws, it now stands out more clearly, undermining fairness, endangering basic rights, and obstructing long-term progress.

At the same time, actions taken at the regional level have strengthened worldwide measures.

Starting in 1999, the Group of States against Corruption, hosted by the Council of Europe, began assessing national systems aimed at curbing corruption, using oversight and mutual evaluations. These steps show that progress depends not only on laws being passed but also on ongoing scrutiny, development of skills, and real-world application.

In truth, tackling corruption demands worldwide involvement, since no nation handles it alone. Through agreements, mutual evaluations, and updated governance methods, shared progress has shaped stronger responses. Such coordinated actions help nations build integrity systems grounded in law, openness, responsibility, and measurable outcomes.



VIII. Possible Solutions

Fighting corruption well means using several methods together: changing how systems work and improving collaboration between countries, leaving less room for secrecy in official actions. Attention now turns toward making anti-corruption bodies stronger nationally, especially by reducing ties to shifting political agendas. Clarity around what each body should do helps stability, and so does openness when choosing who leads them. Funding levels matter; without enough money and tools, tasks cannot be completed properly. Assignments need clear expectations. Oversight done by separate parties supports balance. Updates made visible to people at set intervals allow tracking of progress over time.

Performance becomes clearer when results appear outside internal reviews.

One way to fight corruption involves making government operations clearer to citizens. Where laws now require disclosure, people can view how purchases are made and budgets managed, followed through web-based channels. When financial details appear online, choices shift away from personal judgment toward documented procedures. Systems that store data digitally tend to leave traces, reducing hidden influences behind decisions. Access to real-time updates on spending often discourages misuse simply because actions become visible. Some regions rely on automated reporting to ensure consistency across departments. Published agendas, paired with recorded outcomes, help observers spot irregularities faster. Processes lacking secrecy create conditions where improper conduct faces higher exposure. Public availability of documents does not stop misconduct automatically but raises detection chances. Tools built into administrative workflows support oversight without requiring constant human monitoring.

Where global financial networks enable corrupt practices, coordinated responses across borders become essential. Because multinational firms can operate in multiple jurisdictions, isolated efforts tend to fail. Information exchange between domestic authorities improves detection of illegal transactions spanning countries. When one nation identifies suspicious activity, timely alerts to others prevent concealment through movement of assets. Support from bodies like UNODC allows governments to align laws with international standards. Legal systems gain clarity when advised by experienced external entities familiar with varied regulatory environments. Frameworks grow more resilient not by design alone, but through repeated testing and adjustment guided by shared knowledge. Even so, some argue that creating organizations by themselves does little. Obstacles remain for corruption fighting bodies - political meddling often undermines them, their power to act

is narrow, funding trails off. Because of this, attention has turned toward deeper changes: shielding courts from influence, clarifying divisions between branches of government, upgrading how public services operate. Thus, lasting progress depends less on frameworks alone, more on overhauling underlying systems that uphold responsibility within state machinery. Building skills matters most where resources are limited. When officers and oversight staff receive instruction, effectiveness grows; insight follows through systems that track results alongside openness. From outside the government, watchdog groups contribute just as much. Reporters who investigate misconduct, local observers, nonprofit bodies - these reveal wrongdoing, inform populations, push reform forward. One illustration: an alliance named Transparency International compiles evidence on graft, shares knowledge of dangers involved, urges improved legal frameworks against it.

Ultimately, tackling corruption remains a persistent global priority demanding extended commitment. Not solvable by single actors - progress follows alignment between countries, regions, and institutions. Though tools exist in abundance, real impact emerges only when those involved choose to act. Without consistent exchange across borders, systems meant to uphold openness, responsibility, fairness may stall.

IX. Questions delegates should consider during Research

- How can the independence of national anti-corruption agencies from the government be guaranteed without threatening the country's sovereignty?
- How has my country contributed to the fight against corruption?
- What measures could be taken to make my country's anti-corruption agency (or anti-corruption agencies in general) more effective and transparent?
- How can states strengthen international cooperation on border-crossing corruption and financial crime?
- To what extent does my country support the monitoring of my financial activities and transactions by international organizations?

X. Useful sources

- <https://uncaccoalition.org/the-uncac/united-nations-convention-against-corruption/>
- <https://www.transparency.org/en/cpi/2025>
- <https://www.transparency.org/en/projects/strengthening-enforcement-of-the-oecd-anti-bribery-convention-1>
- <https://www.oecd.org/en/topics/anti-corruption-and-integrity.html>
- <https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/worldwide-governance-indicators>
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- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Corrupt_Practices_Investigation_Bureau
- https://www.unodc.org/documents/corruption/G20-Anti-Corruption-Resources/Leaders-Communiques/2020_G20_Anti-corruption_ministers_speeches_and_remarks_given_during_the_first-ever_G20_anti-corruption_ministerial_meeting.pdf